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Ardmore commissioners respond to Flock recall petitions

Kendall Timms, KTEN News

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ARDMORE, Okla. (KTEN) — Phase two of the petitions to recall four Ardmore city commissioners is here, but this time the petitions include responses from each commissioner.

"We already made our decision, and we're not backing down," said Jeri Keith, an Ardmore business owner who signed the petition.

That's the reaction from some residents who signed those petitions, which each need 1,070 signatures in 30 days to go to a special election.

"We're just ready for a major change," added Keith.

That sentiment remains even though commissioners announced that their next meeting will include a vote on whether or not Ardmore continues to use Flock for police surveillance.

"I sat down with the city manager and the police chief and discussed it with them," said Ardmore Mayor David Plesher.

Plesher said he voted in favor of Flock because of how it assists law enforcement.

"Our streets are public streets, and there's no privacy on public streets... period," the mayor said.

But due to public interest and what Plesher calls "social media scrutiny" surrounding the cameras, he's open to change.

"I'm okay with giving the people the vote on it," he said.

While Plesher said he has spoken with many constituents who support Flock, other citizens have raised concerns that the cameras infringe on their privacy.

Commissioner Buddy Simon said he tried to relay that message to fellow members.

"I don't want to be tracked and traced; I don't believe my neighbors want to be tracked and traced," said Keith, the business owner.

If commissioners agree to let voters decide Flock's fate, Mayor Plesher originally said the city would put bags over the cameras until the final vote in February.

"I am walking that statement back," Plesher said, adding that if the vote for a public referendum passes, there will be a separate agenda item during the meeting where commissioners decide whether the cameras will remain on or be turned off, awaiting election results.

"If the people decide that they want them pulled down, then we will do it at that time," explained Plesher.

The meeting where these topics will be decided is set for September 21.

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